

gondoliers, who helped to spread its fame far and wide.

**“Delight must be the basis and aim of this art.
Simple melody – clear rhythm!”**

GIOACHINO ROSSINI, LETTER, 1868

If *Tancredi* was his breakthrough, *L’italiana in Algeri* was his first runaway success. Written at a furious pace to help out an impresario who had an unexpected gap in his schedule, the opera was premiered in Venice in 1813. It featured a mix of drama with madcap comedy, some of which was clearly inspired by the clownish antics of the *commedia dell’arte* (traditional Italian street theater). Rossini felt galvanized by the need for speed—“ nothing spurs inspiration more than necessity,” he commented—though he also farmed out the recitative and at least one of the arias to an unknown assistant.

Rossini’s success drew the attention of other promoters. Domenico Barbaja (see [box](#)) was the most influential of these and, in 1815, he persuaded the composer to move to Naples, where Rossini became musical director of the royal theaters.

Rossini also found time to write for other theaters. *The Barber of Seville*, for example, was first performed in Rome. It had a stormy opening night, partly because of demonstrations from supporters of a rival production and partly because a stray cat wandered onto the stage. But from the second night onward, *The Barber* was a triumph and has since become Rossini’s most popular creation.